

SUBJUNCTIVE MOOD IN TIGRINYA?*

Gioia Cacchioli
gioia.cacchioli@unige.ch

Abstract: The goal of this squib is to contribute to a better understanding of subjunctive mood by providing novel data on the understudied Ethio-semitic language Tigrinya (SOV, Eritrea and northern Ethiopia). I suggest that the clausal prefix *ki-*, that is selected by many different verb classes and is used to build several different constructions, is a subjunctive marker. I support this idea by presenting a varied amount of data that shows that *ki-* appears (for the most part) in contexts that trigger subjunctive mood in other languages.

Keywords: Subjunctive, Complementizers, Prefixes, Tigrinya, Ethio-semitic

1. Introduction

In the literature, it has been noted that in some languages of the world, subjunctive mood is overtly marked with a morpheme on the verb. This is the case for Hungarian, exemplified below.

- (1) Gyuri azt akarja hogy Lajos egy regényt írjon
Gyuri that want.3S that Lajos a novel write.3S.SUBJ
'Gyuri would like Lajos to write a novel.' (from Baunaz & Puskás (2022:2, (1d)))

In other languages, subjunctive mood is not overtly marked as a morpheme on the verb, but it is conveyed by particles that look like complementizers. This is the case for Modern Greek, that employs the mood particle and subordinator *na* in subjunctive contexts, as shown in (2).

- (2) Thelo na kerdisi o Janis
want.1S NA win.3S the John
'I want John to win.' (from Giannakidou (2009:1887,(10)))

It has also been noted that languages vary with regard to the choice of mood in subordinate clauses. For example, Spanish only admits indicative mood with the verb *believe*, whereas this verb triggers subjunctive mood in Italian (with some speakers marginally accepting indicative mood). This is illustrated in the examples below.

- (3) Creo que llega/*llege hoy
believe.1S that arrive.3S.IND/.SUBJ today
'I believe she arrives today.' (adapted from Baunaz & Puskás (2022:13,(11)))
- (4) Credo che %arriva/arrivi oggi
believe.1S that arrive.3S.IND/.SUBJ today
'I believe she/he arrives today.'

Subjunctive mood has been investigated in several Indo-European languages (Romance, Germanic, Balkan languages and Modern Greek) and also in Semitic languages (mainly Arabic

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and Hebrew). In Standard Arabic, subjunctive mood is obtained by suffixing the morpheme *-a* to a jussive/imperfective form of the verb (Birnstiel 2019:385), as shown in (5).

- (5) ʔaxad-a ʔal- kitāb kay na-nǝur-a ʔilai-hi
 take.PFV-3MS the-book so that 1P-look-SUBJ to-him
 ‘He took the book so that we look at it.’

However, to my knowledge, subjunctive mood has never been investigated in Ethio-semitic languages. This squib takes into consideration subjunctive mood in the Ethio-semitic language Tigrinya, spoken in Eritrea and Ethiopia. As far as I am aware, in the descriptive grammars and in the few works on the syntax of this language, it has never been claimed that Tigrinya possesses subjunctive mood. However, I think that, differently from Classical Arabic and similarly to Modern Greek, Tigrinya expresses subjunctive mood not with a verbal morpheme, but with a particle that introduces some subordinate clauses. The particle that I think can be considered a subjunctive mood marker is the clausal prefix *ki-*, as shown in (6) below.¹ Even though the English translation does not show subjunctive mood, in Italian and French this context would require it, as shown in (7).

- (6) ʔindʒera **ki**-ti-belʃ delej-ε-ja
 Injera KI-SM.3FS-eat.IPFV want.GER-SM.1S-OM.3FS
 ‘I wanted her to eat *injera*.’

- (7) (a) Volev-o che mang-**iasse** dell’ injera
 want.IPFV-1S that want.3F/MS-SUBJ some injera
 ‘I wanted her/him to eat *injera*.’

- (b) Je voul-ais qu’ elle mang-**e** de l’ injera
 I want.IPFV-1S that she want.3FS-SUBJ PART the injera
 ‘I wanted her to eat *injera*.’

The embedded clause in (6) could clearly be considered a subjunctive context, because it is possible to find languages (at least Italian and French) that exhibit subjunctive (morphology or particles) in the same context. However, in Tigrinya, *ki-* also appears in other types of constructions that would not be considered subjunctive contexts, because no other language, to my knowledge, displays subjunctive morphology or particles in the same contexts (these constructions will be presented later). The question is therefore: is *ki-* really a subjunctive mood marker or is it a morpheme that introduces a wider variety of clauses, among which clauses that coincidentally require subjunctive mood in other languages? Actually, is there Subjunctive Mood in Tigrinya at all?

In the following pages, I will present and describe sentences involving the prefix *ki-*; however, I will leave a more in-depth investigation to answer the questions above to future research (cf. Cacchioli, in prep.). In order to compare *ki*-clauses to clauses in other languages, I will mainly

¹ The Leipzig Glossing Rules have been carefully used throughout the squib. My point of deviation is the use of capital SM and capital OM respectively for subject and object marking morphology on verbal forms. Note that transcription conventions in Tigrinya are subject to significant individual variation. To do justice to the naming conventions of Eritrean and Ethiopian authors, I follow the rules proposed in Meyer & Treis (2021) for citations and references.

base myself on the descriptive contribution of Baunaz & Puskás (2022), given that this current volume of GG@G is dedicated to the second author, Genoveva Puskás. The main goal of this squib is thus to contribute to a better understanding of the phenomenon of subjunctive mood by providing novel data on the understudied language Tigrinya.

Unless otherwise noted, the data presented here were gathered in fieldwork with three Eritrean native speakers of Tigrinya that have been living in Geneva (Switzerland) since the 2010s. The data were collected using standard judgment tasks (of Tigrinya sentences constructed by myself or other consultants) and translations (from French to Tigrinya).

The paper is divided as follows: in the next section, I provide some basic grammatical properties of Tigrinya that are relevant for this study; section 3 is dedicated to the compilation and description of the data on *ki*-clauses; in the last section I summarize.

2. Background on Tigrinya

Tigrinya is an Ethio-semitic language spoken by approximately 9 million people mainly in central Eritrea and in the Tigray region in Northern Ethiopia (Bulakh 2023).

Being a Semitic language, Tigrinya verbal forms are built through non-concatenative root morphology, in which triconsonantal roots convey the core meaning of the words and TAM (tense, aspect, modality) information is obtained by the use of vowel templates. Let us take for example the root d-l-j, that conveys the meaning of *wanting*. From this root it is possible to create verbal forms that express different aspects: the Imperfective is a *prefixal* conjugation, meaning that subject ϕ -features appear as *prefixes* on the verb, as in (8). The Perfective and the Gerundive are *suffixal* conjugations, meaning that subject ϕ -features appear as *suffixes* on the verb, as in (9) and (10). Note that Tigrinya is *pro*-drop.

(8)	ji-deli	(9)	dələj-ε	(10)	dəlij-u
	SM.3MS-want.IPFV		want.PFV-SM.3MS		want.GER-SM.3MS
	‘he wants’		‘he has wanted’		‘he wanted’

As shown in the translation of (8), the Imperfective expresses habitual present tense. The Gerundive, etymologically a converb form introduced through contact with Cushitic languages (Appleyard 2015), has replaced the Perfective in nowadays spoken language and expresses perfectivity (Bulakh 2019). Despite the translation of (9) (based on Nazareth 2011), nowadays the Perfective is only used as a suppletive form for the Gerundive in the presence of prefixes (cf. Cacchioli 2023).

Tigrinya is a head-final language with SOV word order. This is shown in (11).² In complex verb forms that express progressive aspect the verb is accompanied by an auxiliary that follows it, as in (12). Both the verb and the auxiliaries carry subject marking morphology. Subordinate clauses precede matrix clauses, as in (13).

(11)	ʔit-i	sebʔay	n-it-a	lam	Ɂʔetil-w-a
	DEM-MS	man	DOM-DEM-FS	cow	kill.GER-SM.3MS-OM.3FS
	‘The man killed the cow.’ (from Cacchioli (2024:26,(4)))				

² Note that demonstratives are used as determiners in Tigrinya.

(12) mis haft-ɛy ji-ts'awet ʔall-ɛxu
 with sister-POSS.1s SM.1s-play.IPFV BE.PRES-SM.1s
 'I am playing with my sister.'

(13) kɛmzi-xɛd-ɛ ji-fellit
 COMP-leave.PFV-SM.3ms SM.1s-know.IPFV
 'I know that he left.'

With these few basic grammatical properties of Tigrinya in mind, we can now turn to the phenomenon under investigation: subjunctive mood.

3. The data

This section contains an overview of *ki*-clauses. In the first subsection, I lay out examples that show that *ki*- appears in Tigrinya where subjunctive markers appear in other languages. In contrast, in the second subsection, I present data on some *ki*-clauses that are more difficultly linked to subjunctive mood.

3.1. ... Subjunctive!

In this section I give an overview of cases that can easily be considered subjunctive contexts by comparing Tigrinya sentences to the same sentences in other languages. I will provide data on emotive factives, directives, future-referring verbs, modals, negative imperatives and purpose/rationale clauses.

3.1.1. Directives

Baunaz & Puskás (2022) claim that the mood of the verb (either indicative or subjunctive) in a subordinate clause in the presence of a specific verb varies from one language to the other. However, they also suggest that there seem to be cases that are similar across languages. The first type of verbs that appear to select subjunctive mood cross-linguistically are directive verbs such as *order* and *suggest*. For instance, this is true for Hungarian, French and Italian (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:21), as in (14a) for Italian, but also for Tigrinya, as in (14b), and English, as in the translations of (14) and (15).

- (14) a. Abbiamo ordinato che part-isse
 have.PRES.1P order.PART-MS that leave.3S-SUBJ
 'We ordered that she leave.'
- b. ki-ti-xɛjid ʔazizi-na
 KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV order.GER-SM.1P
 'We ordered that she leave.'

- (15) **ki-ti-xejid** **hasab** **?aqirebi-na**
 KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV suggestion give.GER-SM.1P
 ‘We suggested that she leave.’

Note that the subordinate clause introduced by *ki-* precedes the matrix verb as befitting a head-final language. Upon scrutiny of the data above, the first fact to point out is that *ki-* is not optional, as shown in (16). The second fact is that *ki-* can only be attached to verbs in Imperfective, hence the ungrammaticality of (17).

- (16) ***ti-xejid** **?azizi-na**
 SM.3FS-leave.IPFV order.GER-SM.1P
- (17) ***ki-ked-et** **?azizi-na**
 KI-leave.PFV-SM.3FS order.GER-SM.1P

By requiring the embedded verb to be marked by *ki-*, Tigrinya seems to behave in accordance with other languages that display subjunctive mood in clauses introduced by this first class of verbs.

3.1.2. *Desire and Future-Referring Verbs*

The second type of verbs that appear to select subjunctive mood cross-linguistically are desire verbs such as *want*, *wish* and *prefer*. Desire verbs trigger subjunctive mood in several languages, among which French, Italian, English and Hungarian (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:21). The verbs that desire verbs embed are marked by the prefix *ki-* in Tigrinya, as illustrated below (example (18) is example (6) from the introduction).

- (18) **?indʒera** **ki-ti-belʃ** **dələj-ε-ja**
 injera KI-SM.3FS-eat.IPFV want.GER-SM.1S-OM.3FS
 ‘I wanted her to eat *injera*.’
- (19) **ki-ti-xejid** **təmeni-na**
 KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV wish.GER-SM.1P
 ‘We wished that she left.’
- (20) **k-i-zewir** **ji-merritsʹ**
 KI-SM.1S-walk.IPFV SM.1S-prefer.IPFV
 ‘I prefer walking.’

With regard to volition verbs such as *want*, in French, Italian, English and Hungarian, the subject of subjunctive clauses must be “referentially disjoint from that of matrix clauses” (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:18) inducing Subject Obviation. In contrast, the subject of indicative clauses can freely corefer with the subject of the matrix clause. In other words, in these languages when *want* is a subject-control verb (such as in *I want to do something*) the embedded verb can be either in indicative or subjunctive mood; when *want* is an ECM verb (such as in *I want somebody to do something*) the embedded verb must be in subjunctive mood. However, Modern Greek, Bulgarian

and Romanian, allow subject coreference in subjunctive contexts (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:29). This is shown in (21) for French and (22) for Modern Greek.

- (21) a. Je veux résoudre le problème
I want.1S solve.3S.INF the problem
'I want to solve the problem.'
- b. Je veux que tu résolves le problème
I want.1S that you solve.3S.SUBJ the problem
'I want you to solve the problem.'

- (22) Thelo **na** liso to provlima
want.1S SUBJ solve.3S the problem
'I want to solve the problem.' (adapted from Roussou (2010:583,(1d)))

Now, where does Tigrinya stand with regard to this? Example (18) shows that the *ki-* prefix appears when *want* is an ECM verb (with a consequent subject obviation). Is *ki-* also triggered when *want* is a control verb (without subject obviation)? The answer is yes. Tigrinya and Classical/Standard Arabic behave like Modern Greek: the verb *want* in these languages requires respectively the *ki-* prefix and the suffixal subjunctive marker *a-*, as illustrated in (23) and (24).

- (23) n-it-i ts'egem k-i-fetiḥ-o ji-deli
DOM-DEM-MS problem KI-SM.1S-solve.IPFV-OM.3MS SM.1S-want.IPFV
'I want to solve the problem.'
- (24) ʔu-rid-u ʔan ʔa-hull-a ʔal-muʃkila
1S-want-IPFV that 1S-want-SUBJ the-problem
'I want to solve the problem.'

Going back to the desire verbs *want* and *wish*, these verbs are sometimes classified as *future referring* verbs (Baunaz & Puskás 2014). In Balkan languages, future referring verbs select subjunctive mood (Sočanac 2017). This class of verbs also include *expect*. This verb selects a *ki-* clause in Tigrinya, as shown in (25).

- (25) Tesfai ʔane k-i-ḥigiz-o ji-ts'ebiji-ni
Tsfay I KI-SM.1S-help.IPFV-OM.3MS SM.3MS-expect.IPFV-OM.1S
'Tsfay expects me to help him.'

Before turning to modal verbs, it is important to mention that not only do *ki-* clauses appear in the presence of *future* referring verbs, but they are also used to express *future* tense in Tigrinya. This construction requires the individual-level copula to appear in final position and to agree with the subject of the sentence.

- (26) Tesfay ʔaḥmilti k-i-belʃ ʔi-jju
Tsfay vegetables KI-SM.3MS-eat.IPFV COP.PRES-SM.3MS
'Tsfay will eat vegetables.' (from Cacchioli (2024:28,(13)))

The datapoint above is quite striking: if *ki-* is a subjunctive marker, why would it be used to express future tense? As a matter of fact, this makes sense if we consider that the subjunctive is known to semantically be associated to *irrealis* contexts (Giannakidou 2009, Baunaz & Puskás 2022). The term *irrealis* is used to refer to an event/state that is possible and conceivable and not one that has actually happened or is happening (Matthews 2007). Irrealis mood therefore encodes that “some state of affairs is not real or only possible or at least that the speaker does not express his commitment to the reality of the state of affairs” (van der Auwera & Devos 2012: 171). Future constructions could maybe then be thought of as irrealis contexts, which, as mentioned, are closely related to subjunctive mood.

3.1.3. Modals

The third and last type of verbs that appear to select subjunctive mood cross-linguistically are modal verbs in impersonal constructions such as *be possible* and *be necessary* (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:21). This is illustrated below for Italian and (formal) English.

- (27) È possibile che stia/*sta a casa
 BE.PRES.3MS possible that stare.3MS.SUBJ/IND at home
 ‘It is possible that he will stay home.’

- (28) It’s necessary that you be/*are on time. (from Baunaz & Puskás (2022:21,(28c)))

In Romance, Germanic and Hungarian modal verbs do not select for subjunctive mood unless they are found in impersonal constructions. However, the verbs *must*, *should* and *can* trigger subjunctive mood in Balkan languages (Sočanac 2017) and the verbs *must*, *should*, *can* and *may* do the same in Modern Greek (Giannakidou 2009, Roussou 2010, Baunaz & Puskás 2022).

With regard to Tigrinya, deontic modal verbs such as *must* (the root /hlw/ in Tigrinya, literally *have to*), *should* (the root /gbʔ/ in Tigrinya, literally *need to*) and *can* (the root /kʔl/) select for a *ki-*marked verb, as shown in the three examples below.

- (29) ʔit-a sɛbejti ki-ti-xejjid ji-gibbaʔ-(a)
 DEM-FS woman KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV SM.3MS-need_to.IPFV-OM.3FS
 ‘The woman should/needs to leave.’ (from Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted:14,(34a)))

- (30) ʔit-a sɛbejti ki-ti-xejjid ʔall-ɛw-*(a)
 DEM-FS woman KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV have_to.PFV-SM.3MS-OM.3FS
 ‘The woman has to leave.’ (from Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted:14,(34b)))

- (31) ʔit-a sɛbejti ki-ti-xejjid ti-xiʔil
 DEM-FS woman KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV SM.3FS-can.IPFV
 ‘The woman can leave.’ (from Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted:30,(76)))

Note that in (29) the modal verb carries default 3MS agreement and is optionally suffixed by object marking morphology that cross-references the subject *ʔita sɛbejti* ‘the woman’. This object marker is instead obligatory on the modal in (30) that also carries default 3MS subject agreement. In contrast, the modal in (31) agrees with the subject and does not carry object morphology. For a

more extensive description and a more in-depth syntactic analysis of modals in Tigrinya, see Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted), but also Gebregziabher (2021) and Tesfay (2016).

Contrary to deontic modals, the epistemic modal *might* (the root /kwn/ in Tigrinya, literally *become*) does not select for a *ki*-marked verb, as shown in (32).

- (32) ʔit-a səbeʃti ti-xejjid ti-xiwwin
 DEM-FS woman SM.3FS-leave.IPFV SM.3FS-might.IPFV
 ‘The woman might leave.’ (from Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted:14,(33))

Cacchioli & Overfelt (submitted) claim that the modal /kwn/ does not select for a *ki*-marked verb because it is an auxiliary in a monoclausal construction.

With regard to modal verbs and subjunctive mood, Tigrinya seems to behave more closely to Balkan languages.

3.1.4. *Emotive Factives*

So far, I have presented classes of verbs that are claimed to select subjunctive mood cross linguistically. Now, I will turn to those classes that differ across languages with regard to their triggering of indicative or subjunctive mood. These are, for example, emotive factives such as *regret*, *be happy* and *be surprised*. These predicates require the subjunctive mood in Romance languages, but indicative mood in languages such as English and Hungarian (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:22). In Tigrinya, they require embedded *ki*-marked verbs. This is illustrated below.

- (33) **ki**-ti-xejjid ni-t’aʃes
 KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV SM.1P-regret.IPFV
 ‘We regret that she leaves.’
- (34) **ki**-ti-xejjid ʃigos-at ʔi-na
 KI-SM.3FS-leave.IPFV happy-P COP.PRES-SM.1P
 ‘We are happy that she leaves.’

With regard to emotive factives, Tigrinya thus seems to behave more closely to Romance languages than English and Hungarian.

3.1.5. *Negative Imperatives*

In Hungarian, subjunctive and imperative moods seem to share (some of) the same morphology (Baunaz & Puskás 2022:157), to the extent that it has been argued that some imperative clauses in the language are “special cases of subjunctive (i.e.) matrix subjunctive clauses” (Kádár & Peredy 2014). In Tigrinya, imperatives are not marked by the *ki*- prefix. However, negative imperatives can.

Sentential negation in Tigrinya is expressed by the circumfix ʔaj-...(i)n. However, in some cases, such as imperative clauses, the suffix -(i)n does not appear. This is shown in (35b).

- (35) a. ti-sitə!
SM.2MS-drink.IMP
'Drink!'
b. ʔaj-ti-sitə!
NEG-SM.2MS-drink.IMP
'Don't drink!'

Now, the interesting and relevant point for us here is that it is also possible to negate an imperative with the *ki-* prefix. This is illustrated in (36) below.

- (36) k-εj-ti-sitə!
KI-NEG-SM.2MS-drink.IMP
'Don't drink!'

My consultants claim that there is no difference in meaning between the negative imperative in (35b) and the one in (36).³ Note that *ki-* is the outermost prefix in the verbal form in (36) and that its prefixation causes the glottal stop of the negative prefix to drop and the vowel [a] to change into [ε].⁴

Before moving to the next section, I would like to point out the fact that imperatives are future oriented. In section 3.1.2, I have shown that *ki-* is used to express future tense (along with an obligatory copula); it is therefore not surprising to see *ki-* playing a role in imperatives as well. As a matter of fact, in Standard Arabic, the subjunctive mood is also used when negating a future tense, as illustrated in (37) below.

- (37) a. sa-ʔa-ðhab-u ʔilā ʔal-madrasa yaðan
FUT-1S-go-IPFV to the-school tomorrow
'I will go to school tomorrow.'
b. lan ʔa-ðhab-a ʔilā ʔal-madrasa yaðan
NEG SM.1S-go-SUBJ to the-school tomorrow
'I won't go to school tomorrow.'

Example (37a) shows that in Standard Arabic the particle *sa-* (or *saufa*) is used to express future tense along with a verb in Imperfective. Example (37b) shows that the particle *lan* is used to negate the future; in this case the verb is in subjunctive.

3.1.6. Purpose/Rationale Clauses

So far, I have presented data that shows *ki-* appearing in Tigrinya where subjunctive mood is required in other languages. In the next section, I will provide data that links more difficultly *ki-* to subjunctive mood. This last subsection is exactly in the middle of all this: *ki-* occurs in

³ I personally do not believe in optionality in language and thus think that there must be a very slight difference between the two interpretations that my non-linguist consultants cannot grasp.

⁴ This phonological process is not exclusive to *ki-*, but takes place with other clausal prefixes as well (cf. Cacchioli 2023).

purpose/rationale clauses in Tigrinya and these clauses exhibit subjunctive mood in other languages, but it is difficult to explain why.

As (38) illustrates, rationale clauses display the particle *miʔinti* ‘in order to’ and a *ki*-marked verb. The element *miʔinti* is optional and if deleted, the purpose clause still requires *ki*- to be prefixed onto the embedded verb.

- (38) fetena (miʔinti) k-i-ħaliḥ ʔatalil-u
 exam in_order_to KI-SM.3MS-pass.IPFV cheat.GER-SM.3MS
 ‘He cheated in order to pass the exam.’

To my knowledge, other languages that require subjunctive mood in purpose clauses are Standard Arabic and Latin. To construct this type of clauses, the particle *li* ‘to/for’ is used in the former and the particle *ut* ‘(in order) to/that’ is used in the latter; both particles are accompanied by a verb in subjunctive. This is shown in the two examples below.

- (39) yaḥ-a li-ja-nzaḥ-a fī ʔal-imtiḥān
 cheat.PFV-3MS to-SM.3MS-pass-SUBJ in the-exam
 ‘He cheated in order to pass the exam.’

- (40) Venit ut eam vid-ea-t
 come.PRES.3MS in order to her see-SUBJ-3S
 ‘He comes in order to see her.’

Why is subjunctive required in rationale and purpose clauses in some languages? My guess would be that these clauses are future-oriented and therefore could be thought of as involving an irrealis context. As previously mentioned, the subjunctive is known to be associated to irrealis semantically.

3.2. ... Subjunctive?

In this section I give a quick overview of some cases that cannot easily be considered subjunctive contexts by comparing Tigrinya sentences with other languages. I will provide data on Control constructions, ECM constructions and simultaneity.

3.2.1. Control and ECM

The first contexts that I will mention in this paper that present *ki*- but are difficult to be linked to subjunctive mood contexts are control and ECM constructions. When the subject-control verbs *try*, *hope*, *promise*, *choose* and *ask* are in a matrix clause, they require the embedded verb to be *ki*-marked. This is shown in the examples below.

- (41) Tesfai dmu k-i-siʔei fettin-u
 Tesfay cat KI-SM.3MS-draw.IPFV try.GER-SM.3MS
 ‘Tesfay tried to draw a cat.’

- (42) ʔaman sirah k-i-rikəb ji-ʔəmin
 Aman work/job KI-SM.3MS-find.IPFV SM.3MS-hope.IPFV
 ‘Aman hopes to find a job.’

I already showed in section 3.1.2 that the ECM verb *expect* triggers the presence of *ki-* onto the embedded verb. This is also true for ECM/perception verbs such as *see* and *hear*, as shown below. Despite the presence of the pronoun *them* in the English translations of the examples above, an object marker cross-referencing the object *nissatom* ‘they’ on the matrix verb is optional (I will not discuss this further here).

- (43) nissatom k-i-mərʕa-wu riʔəj-ε
 they KI-SM.3MP-marry.IPFV-SM.3MP⁵ see.GER-SM.1S
 ‘I saw them getting married.’

- (44) nissatom k-i-sehaqu səmiʕ-ε
 they KI-SM.3MP-laugh.IPFV-SM.3MP hear.GER-SM.1S
 ‘I heard them laughing.’

How to explain the presence of *ki-* in these cases? If for control constructions I cannot find a valid explanation at the present time, I hypothesize the following for perception verbs. It has been claimed that subjunctive mood is dependent on the matrix tense, whereas indicative mood is independent (Giannakidou 2009, Baunaz & Puskás 2022). The *ki*-clauses in (43) and (44) would be considered non-finite clauses in English and therefore, dependent clauses. In Tigrinya, the *ki*-clauses are not non-finite given that the form of the *ki*-marked verb, the Imperfective, is found also in root clauses. However, one could claim that the temporal interpretation of *ki*-clauses is dependent on the matrix verb. In fact, if we change the tense of the matrix clause of the sentences above, the temporal interpretation of the *ki*-clause also change: for example, in (44) the event of laughing took place in the past, whereas in (45) it takes place at speech time.

- (45) nissatom k-i-sehaqu ji-səmiʕ
 they KI-SM.3MP-laugh.IPFV-SM.3MP SM.1S-hear.IPFV
 ‘I hear them laughing.’

Being *ki*-clauses temporally dependent on matrix verbs, it would not be surprising to find languages that require subjunctive mood in the same context.

3.2.1. *Simultaneity*

The second context that I will mention in this paper that involve *ki-* but is difficult to be linked to subjunctive mood is the expression of simultaneity. Consider (46) and (47).

⁵ In Imperfective plural 2nd and 3rd persons present subject agreement as both prefixes and suffixes. It is suggested that the prefix marks person and the suffix marks both gender and number, but there is no clear consensus in the literature. For the sake of simplicity I just added the same agreement marker (3MP) twice.

- (46) **k-i-belʃ** **k-ell-əxu** nissu riʔiy-u-ni
 KI-SM.1S-eat.IPFV KI-AUX.PRES-1S he see.GER-SM.3MS-OM.1S
 ‘While I was eating, he saw me.’ (from Cacchioli (2023:256,(32)))
- (47) ʔit-a dimu **ki-ti-beraber-ini** **k-ell-a**
 DEM-FS cat.FS KI-SM.3FS-wake_up.IPFV-OM.1S KI-AUX.PRES-SM.3FS
 ʔane deki-s-ε neyr-ε
 I sleep.GER-SM.1S COP.GER-SM.1S
 ‘I was asleep while the cat was waking me up.’

In the embedded clauses in the examples above, the verbal forms are complex: a verb in Imperfective is accompanied by an auxiliary. The *ki-* prefix is (obligatorily) attached to both the verb and the auxiliary. This gives the interpretation of *while* (note that in contrast with the English translations, there is no overt temporal lexical item in the Tigrinya sentences). Can this construction be considered a subjunctive mood context? And why does *ki-* appears on both the verb and the auxiliary?

The second question will be left to future research (Cacchioli, in prep.), but it was already answered for another clausal prefix that appears on both the verb and the auxiliary in complex verb forms (the prefix *zi-*) in Cacchioli (2023). The answer to the first question, I think, is *yes*. As said in the previous section, *ki*-clauses seem to be dependent on the matrix clause. In (46) and (47) this is also the case: the event of the embedded clauses is conveyed by an Imperfective verb and an auxiliary whose temporal interpretation depend on the tense of the matrix verb. Thus, also in this case, I think that it would not be surprising to find languages that require subjunctive mood (morphology or particles) in the same context.

4. CONCLUSIONS

In this squib I gave an overview of *ki*-clauses in Tigrinya, describing and providing a conspicuous amount of data on this clausal prefix that seems to be closely linked to subjunctive marking. By following the descriptive data provided in Baunaz & Puskás 2022’s monograph, I showed that *ki-* appears for the most part in clauses in which in other languages we would expect subjunctive. However, I also showed that this prefix appears in contexts that seem at first sight unrelated to this mood. For these cases, I tried to propose hypotheses that would link the use of *ki-* in Tigrinya with subjunctive mood marking. However, a more in-depth analysis is needed to better understand if *ki-* can really be considered as a subjunctive mood particle or not. Moreover, the question that remains therefore open to future research is: is there really *Subjunctive Mood in Tigrinya*?

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